



VIOLENCE IN LALGARH CONTINUES; MAMATA BANERJEE (BELOW) WOULD SEEK TO CAPITALISE ON THE POPULAR IRE AGAINST BUDDHADEB BHATTACHARYA (LEFT)



CPI(M) workers and the PCAPA. Three bodies, claimed to be those of CPI(M) workers, have been found in Dharampur and some party workers are reportedly missing.

To add to the state Government's embarrassment, Union Home Minister P. Chidambaram has said that enough forces have been sent from the Centre but the state forces must also do their work. "The Centre is there to help in every way, but the state has to take responsibility," he said, adding that it seemed the state Government was divided on what steps should be taken in Lalgarh.

The divide inside the Left Front is also evident. Chairman Biman Bose has accused the state administration of not being able to control the violence. He also called upon all his party comrades, saying, "I appeal to all workers to come out on the streets and protest." Besides Lalgarh, local leaders are also critical of the party's decision to withdraw support to the UPA over the nuclear deal issue. On the home front, they feel that the state Government's land acquisition policy had not gone down too well with farmers.

Meanwhile, Trinamool Congress Chief Mamata Banerjee, who had been criticised earlier by the Left Front Government for supporting Maoists in Lalgarh, now says, "What is of prime importance now is that all illegal arms and ammunition present in the state must be seized so that all kinds of violence stops." Senior Revolutionary Socialist Party leader Kshiti Goswami sings a similar tune as he says, "It's undesirable that any political party can gain influence in an area through violence while the police are reduced to being just spectators. A lot of damage has been done. The police should have taken stronger steps earlier."

After enjoying power in its absolute form for three decades in the state, the Left Front now has a Herculean task at hand—that of bridging the gap between the party and the masses. Containing violence in Lalgarh will be an acid test for the state Government to reclaim its lost glory. ■